I owe Malcolm a lot. He was United's London scout and the person who took me up to the club and looked out for me until I moved there permanently. I went up that first time and then back for two or three other trials. I loved it, staying up in Manchester for days or a week at a time, playing soccer and talking about soccer from morning until night. I did everything I could to make the right impression and worked as hard as I could. Eventually, we were told they'd be interested in signing me. One evening at home, the phone rang and Dad answered it. A minute or two later, he came back in with this look on his face, like he couldn't believe what he'd just heard. Of course, this was his dream as well as mine beginning to happen.

'That was Alex Ferguson.'

Everything went quiet.

'He phoned to say they'd enjoyed meeting you, that you've got talent and that they think your character is a credit to you, and to me and Mum.'

And there was more.

'He said you're just the kind of boy Manchester United are looking for.'

That was the first contact I had with the man who became the driving force behind my career. Thinking back, for all my anxiety about whether they would want me or not, maybe I wasn't surprised that the manager knew who I was. The summer before, I'd already had my chance to play in front of a capacity crowd at Old Trafford.

I was ten years old when I attended the Bobby Charlton Soccer School for the first time. I had seen a feature about it on *Blue Peter*. Playing soccer in Manchester? With Bobby Charlton? I suppose Mum and Dad's only choice in the matter was how they were going to fund it: I think Grandad paid in the end. It was a residential soccer school for that first summer, with hundreds of kids from all over the world staying in the university halls of residence while the students were on vacation. It lasted the whole week and I played plenty of soccer, but the rest of the time I felt a bit lost. Mum and Dad came up and stayed with relatives near Liverpool, and I was on the phone to them every evening. I had a toothache. I was homesick. And the week just passed me by a little.

I was desperate to have another go, so I went back the following summer. Things went a lot better. There were skills competitions on each of the courses, which used to run all through the summer, and the winners each